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ALL ORDER IS AT AN END

The morning of 2 November 1841 dawned clear and cold. The oblique winter light threw long, sharp shadows from the Afghan pines and cypresses in the gardens outside Kabul's city walls. Beyond the gardens, in the newly completed cantonment, Captain Hugh Johnson, the paymaster of Shah Shuja's troops, had woken early. He had attended a regimental dinner party the night before and, given the worsening security situation, had been persuaded by his brother officers to spend the night in the cantonment, even though his Afghan mistress was waiting for him in his bed in the Shor Bazaar in the centre of the city.

'At about sun rise & before I was up,' he wrote in his diary that night, 'one of my servants came to inform me that the workmen who had for the last few days been employed on a house I had purchased in the Mission Compound refused to leave their houses today as they were afraid of their property being plundered, a rumour having been spread during the night that a disturbance was to take place in the city.'[1] This Johnson thought unlikely. There had been no signs of imminent trouble in the city before he left the previous evening, and as his house was opposite that of Alexander Burnes he felt sure his friend would have warned him if there had been any intelligence of a disturbance. Nevertheless, 'about ½ an hour after my servant left me to return to the city, three chaprasses came to report that a mob had collected in front of my house and Treasury. They were